

Importing data into an Excel sheet is a fundamental task for consolidating information from external sources like text files, websites, or other databases into a structured spreadsheet format.

Here is a detailed breakdown of how to import and manage external data:

1. Common Data Sources

Excel allows you to pull data from a variety of file types and locations:

- **Text/CSV Files:** The most common format for raw data exports.
- **Web Pages:** Importing live tables or lists directly from a website URL.
- **Databases:** Connecting to SQL Server, Access, or other enterprise database systems.
- **Other Excel Workbooks:** Referencing or pulling data from different .xls or .xlsx files.

2. The Import Process (Power Query)

Modern versions of Excel use **Power Query** (found under the **Data** tab) to handle imports. This provides a user-friendly interface for cleaning data before it reaches the grid.

- **Step 1: Get Data:** Navigate to the **Data** tab and select **Get Data**. Choose your source (e.g., **From File** > **From Text/CSV**).
- **Step 2: Preview:** Excel will show a preview of how the data will look. Here, you can check the "Delimiter" (like a comma or tab) to ensure columns are separated correctly.
- **Step 3: Transform (Optional):** If the data needs cleaning (e.g., removing empty rows or changing a **Cell category**), you can click **Transform Data** to open the Power Query Editor.
- **Step 4: Load:** Select **Load** to bring the data into a new worksheet or an existing range.

3. Managing Imported Data

Once the data is imported, you should apply standard Excel management tools to ensure it remains organized:

- **Format as Table:** It is highly recommended to format imported data as a **Table**. This automatically adds **Auto Filter** buttons to your headers and makes the range dynamic for **Pivot Tables**.
- **Data Validation:** Use validation rules to ensure any new manual entries in the imported list remain consistent with the existing data.
- **Refresh:** If the source file (like a CSV) is updated, you don't need to re-import it. Simply go to the **Data** tab and click **Refresh All** to pull in the latest information.

4. Navigation and Structure After Import

Large data imports often fill up many of the **1,048,576 rows** available in a sheet. Use these shortcuts to manage large imports:

- **Ctrl + PgDn**: Quickly move between different sheets if you imported data into multiple tabs.
- **Ctrl + Down Arrow**: Jump to the **Last row** of your imported data to check for completeness.
- **Find and Replace**: Use this tool to quickly fix any recurring errors or outdated terms in the imported text.